and engaged an illegitimate scion of the dynasty, one Rana Banbir Singh, to assassinate the king.

Having done the deed, Rana Banbir entered the nursery where Rana Sanga's infant son, Udai, had just fallen asleep after his meal of rice and milk. Banbir meant to kill the child and thus rid himself of any future contender for the crown of Mewar. It was the quick thinking of his nurse that saved the boy – she put her own son in Udai's bed, and gave the prince to the cook, who smuggled him away.

And yet, writes Tod, excitable chronicler of the desert kings, the nurse's terrible sacrifice was in vain. Indeed, when Banbir stormed into the nursery with his dagger, 'well had it been for Mewar had the poniard fulfilled its intention, and had the annals never recorded the name of Udai Singh in the catalogue of her princes'.

Tod's scathing indictment of the man under whose rule Chittorgarh would fall for the fourth and final time may sound hyperbolic, but the fact remains: Udai Singh fled his fort even before Akbar arrived.

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On 23 October 1567, days after his twenty-fifth birthday, when Akbar pitched his tents below Chittorgarh, it seemed as if the fortress, too, had upped and left. A great rain was falling, hurled about from side to side by a 'storm of wind' as lightning flashed across the sky.[17] Of the fortress, hidden by clouds, there was no sign.

On a clear day, Chittorgarh would have been hard to miss. The hill on which it rises is the only elevation on a flat landscape. At its base, the hill's perimeter measures 5 or 6 kos, or about 20 kilometres; and the fort itself is among the largest in India, spread across 700 acres. 'Travellers do not speak of any fortress like this in the whole habitable world,' wrote one Mughal historian.[18] Its immense height and thick stone walls made it almost impossible to breach, whether by cannon or rock-hurling catapults. There was water and ammunition aplenty within; Rana Udai Singh had left his army with 'provisions . . . for several years' – and destroyed the countryside so there was 'not even . . . grass in the fields' let alone grain for the Mughal army to eat.[19]

The rana had also left his stronghold in capable hands. Jaimal, the rana's